

DIGITAL COMMUNICATION & PERSONAL BRANDING



NADIA GARFUNKEL

SESSION 4

AGENDA

RECAP

**FOUNDERS IDENTITIES &
FIGUREHEADS**

**PERSONAL BRANDING
& IKIGAI & INTERVIEW QUESTIONS**

***TOP SECRET* CHAT DURING
IN-CLASS LUNCH?**

**FINAL PROJECT &
PRESENTATION
EXPECTATIONS**

RECAP FROM LAST CLASS

Will AI ever have taste? When/how?

Social media platforms award/push content quite differently. Give some examples.

Mark Zuckerberg is reportedly building an AI clone to replace him in meetings



Image: Cath Virginia / The Verge; Getty Images

/ The AI version of Zuckerberg is trained on his mannerisms, tone, and public statements, according to a report from the Financial Times.

by [+ Emma Roth](#)

Apr 13, 2026, 3:40 PM GMT+2



62 Comments (All New)



[+ Emma Roth](#) is a news writer who covers the streaming wars, consumer tech, crypto, social media, and much more. Previously, she was a writer and editor at MUO.

Meta CEO Mark Zuckerberg could soon have an AI clone of himself to interact with and provide feedback to employees, according to a report from the *Financial Times*. Sources tell the outlet that Meta is training the AI avatar on Zuckerberg's image and voice, along with his mannerisms, tone, and public statements, "so that employees might feel more connected to the founder through interactions with it."

FOUNDER AS BRAND ASSET

When the person = the product...

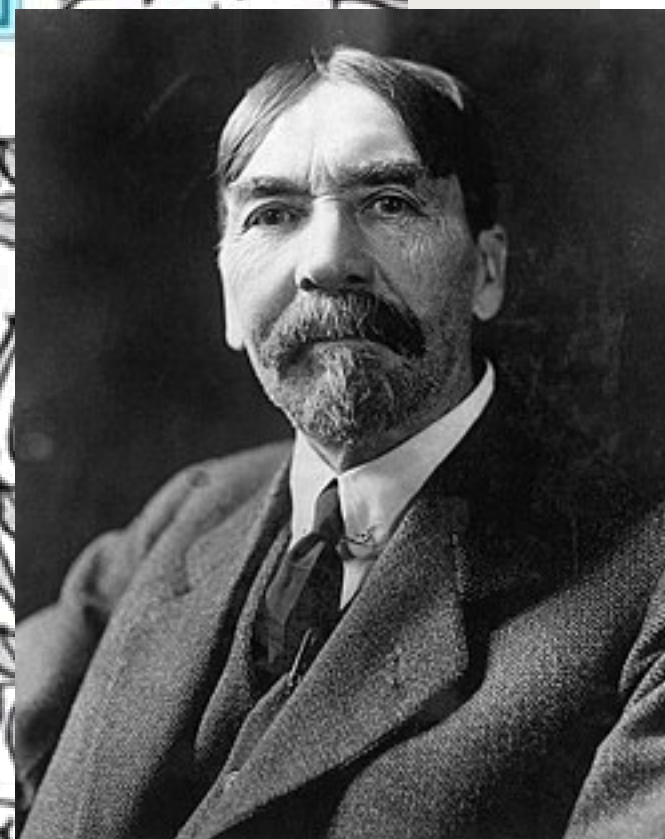
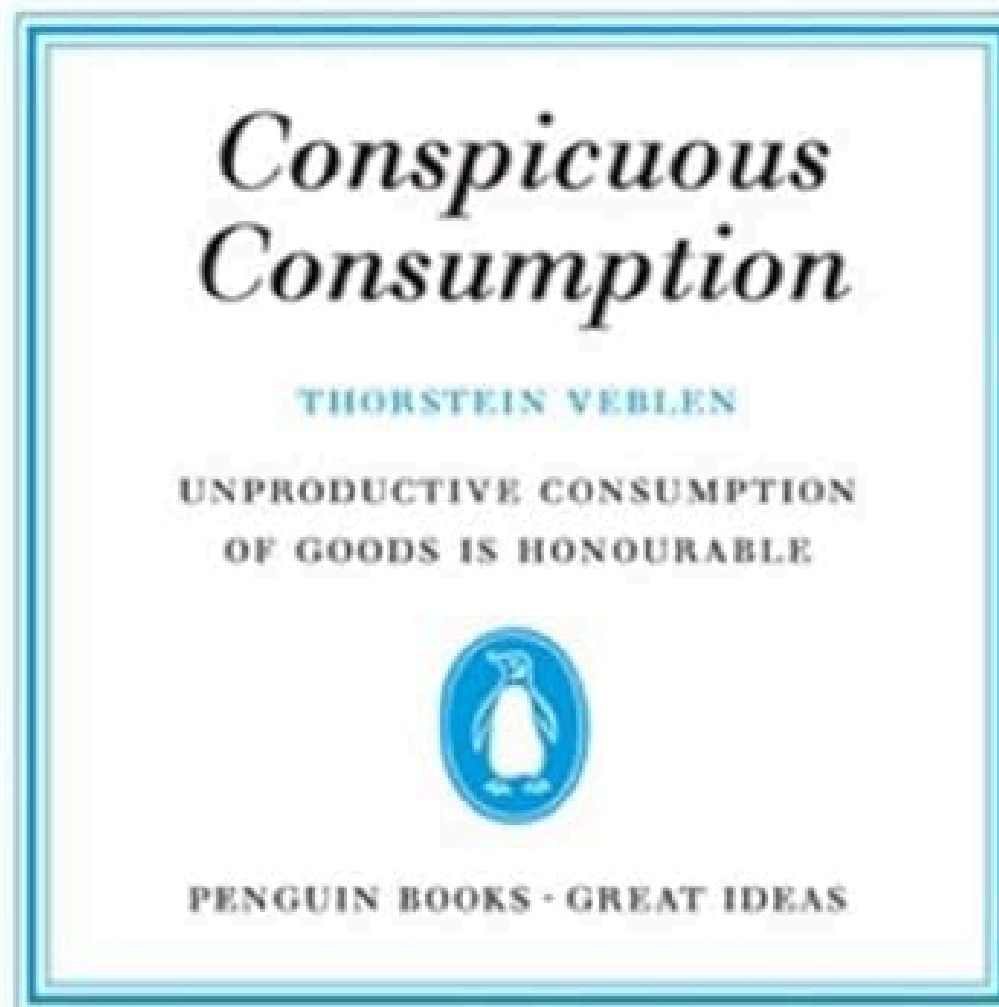
Some brands are inseparable from their notable creator... Give some examples of this!

The word "FENTY" is written in a bold, black, sans-serif font. The letter 'V' is stylized with a diagonal slash through it. The text is centered within a white rectangular box.

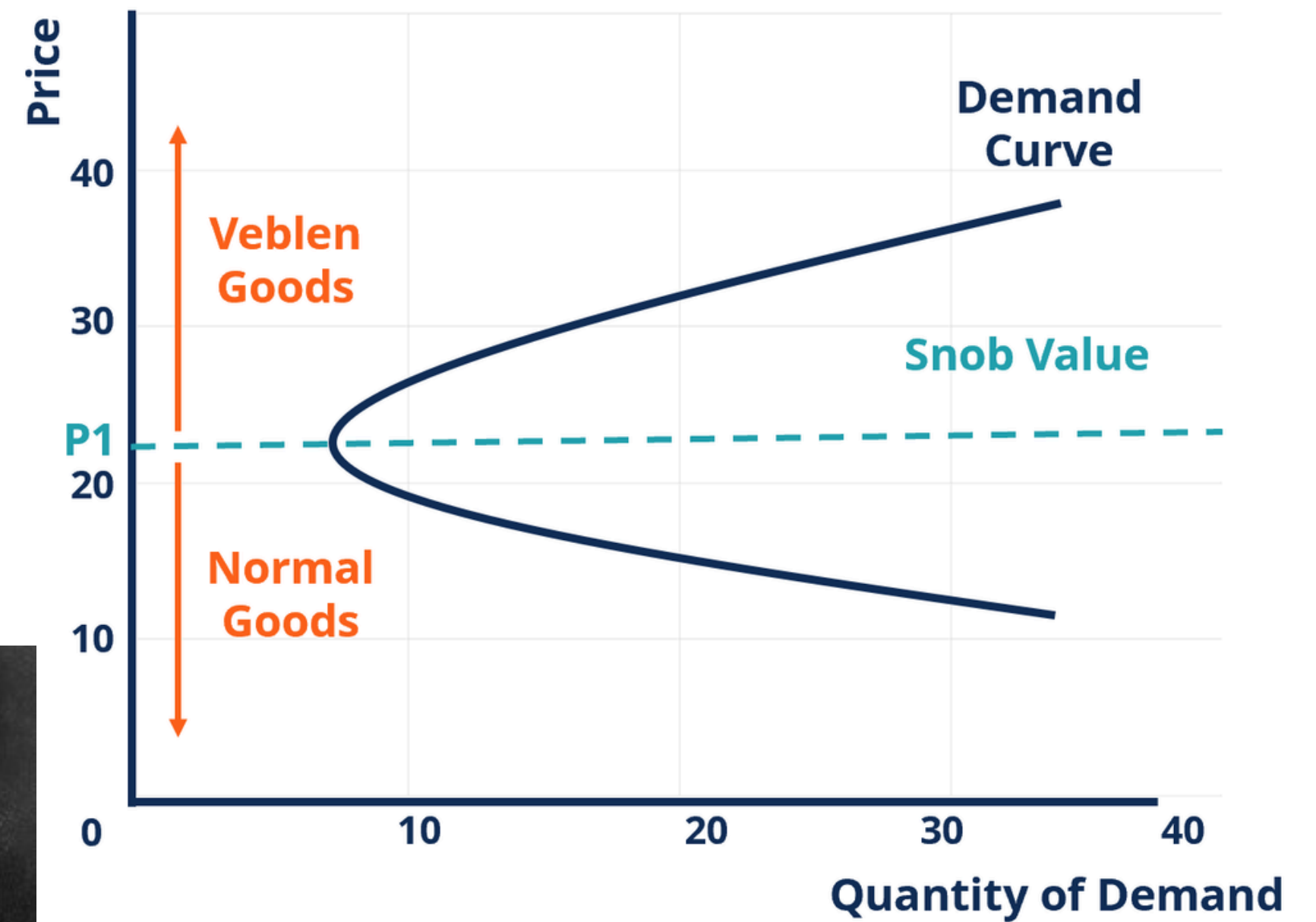
JACQUEMUS



side note



Snob Effect of Veblen Goods





Home

An indispensable resource for finding products, tools, tips, and experts to bring more agency, depth, and joy to life.

goop.com





 momofuku

NETFLIX

FIGUREHEAD ≠ FOUNDER

Not every brand face built the company; some were installed as its symbol.

A figurehead is a strategic casting choice. The person represents the brand's aspirational identity, often with more cultural reach than any founder could achieve.

- **Emma Watson → UN Women / HeForShe — a figurehead selected because her global visibility and personal credibility could make an institutional campaign feel personal and urgent.**
- **Tadashi Yanai → Uniqlo — quietly omnipresent. Yanai rarely does flashy press, but his philosophy of "LifeWear" and Japanese minimalism is embedded so deeply in Uniqlo's DNA that the brand reads as an extension of his worldview.**
- **others?**

**The risk is that figureheads can be replaced, but founders can't.
This is both a strength and a vulnerability!!!**

WHEN THE BRAND OUTLIVES THE PERSON

Is "founder-led" a strategy or a dependency?

The hardest test of founder-brand fusion...

- Virgil Abloh → Off-White / Louis Vuitton – his sudden death froze two brand identities in place. Off-White struggles to evolve past his aesthetic. LV menswear had to consciously choose: honor the legacy, or move on?
- What's going on with OpenAI these days?
- Gregoire Genest deep dive → what does he do well?

PERSONAL BRANDING INTRO

Write on post-its:

Pick 4-5 classmates who have a very distinct “personal brand” (whatever this means to you!). Describe them with a short sentence or keywords, and stick the paper next to their name.

**KHADIDJA
ILIANE
ALEXIS
ALEXANDRA
GABRIEL
JONATHAN
KEIRA
LEA
SHERLEY
OTHMANE
NOAM
THOMAS F.
THEODORE
MARION
NOA**

**THOMAS L.
ROBIN
SOPHIE
ALEXANDRE
SACHA
ENZO
FLORENT
NAMIE
GUILLAUME
DIANA
NATHAN
ANNA
ANAELLE
EYAL**

...PSYCHOLOGY INTRO

**What does “parasocial”
mean and how do brands /
individuals capitalize off of
this phenomenon?**

PERSONAL BRAND

It's what people say about you when you leave the room.

To develop it: shape how others perceive your professional identity ~ skills, values, point of view, and the feeling people associate with you.

- **Signaling theory (economics / evolutionary biology) = your personal brand is a signal.** An earned credential, a consistent LinkedIn presence = costly signals that communicate competence because they take effort to get.
- **Self-determination theory** = the strongest personal brands are built on **intrinsic motivation: autonomy, mastery, purpose**. Brands built purely on external validation (likes, follower counts, etc.!) burn out. Brands built on genuine curiosity and skill compound over time.

So are you in charge of your own brand, or is someone else designing it for you?

...MORE PSYCHOLOGY

**Why do some people
become magnets for
opportunities while others
with equal talent don't?**

- **Halo Effect (Thorndike, 1920): one strong positive impression bleeds into everything else.** People can assume you're competent in areas they haven't even tested you on. This is why a strong portfolio piece or one viral post can open doors disproportionate to its actual content!
- **Narrative Identity (Dan McAdams): humans understand themselves and others through stories.** This is how early-stage VCs invest in founders. A personal brand that has a clear narrative arc — like "I started here, I learned this, I'm going there" — is easier to remember and emotionally easier to support than a list of skills.
- **...exposure...duh!:** people develop preference for things they simply see repeatedly. Familiarity breeds trust, and trust breeds opportunity.



BONUS: WHERE “INTELLECTUALS” ARE

Building a reputation around expertise is happening well beyond the big social media platforms:

- Substack & Medium - long-form essays, blogs, newsletters
- podcasts (as host or guest)
- industry or geo-specific publications - ex. Sifted
- conference talks, panels, guest lectures
- white papers posted on LinkedIn
- *where else?*

WHAT A 21-22 YEAR OLD CAN DO

You don't need to be famous. You need to be **findable** and **understandable** within a short amount of time.

People your age who are doing this well right now:

- “*the niche creator*” - targeted audience via specific interest
- “*builder-in-public*” - someone documenting a project in real time.
Vulnerability + effort = trust.
- “*the connector*” - no original content at all, just someone who curates, introduces people, shares others' work with sharp commentary. Their brand is taste and generosity. 😊

IKIGAI

FRAMEWORK

WHO ARE YOU???

Before you build a personal brand, you need to know what it's about.

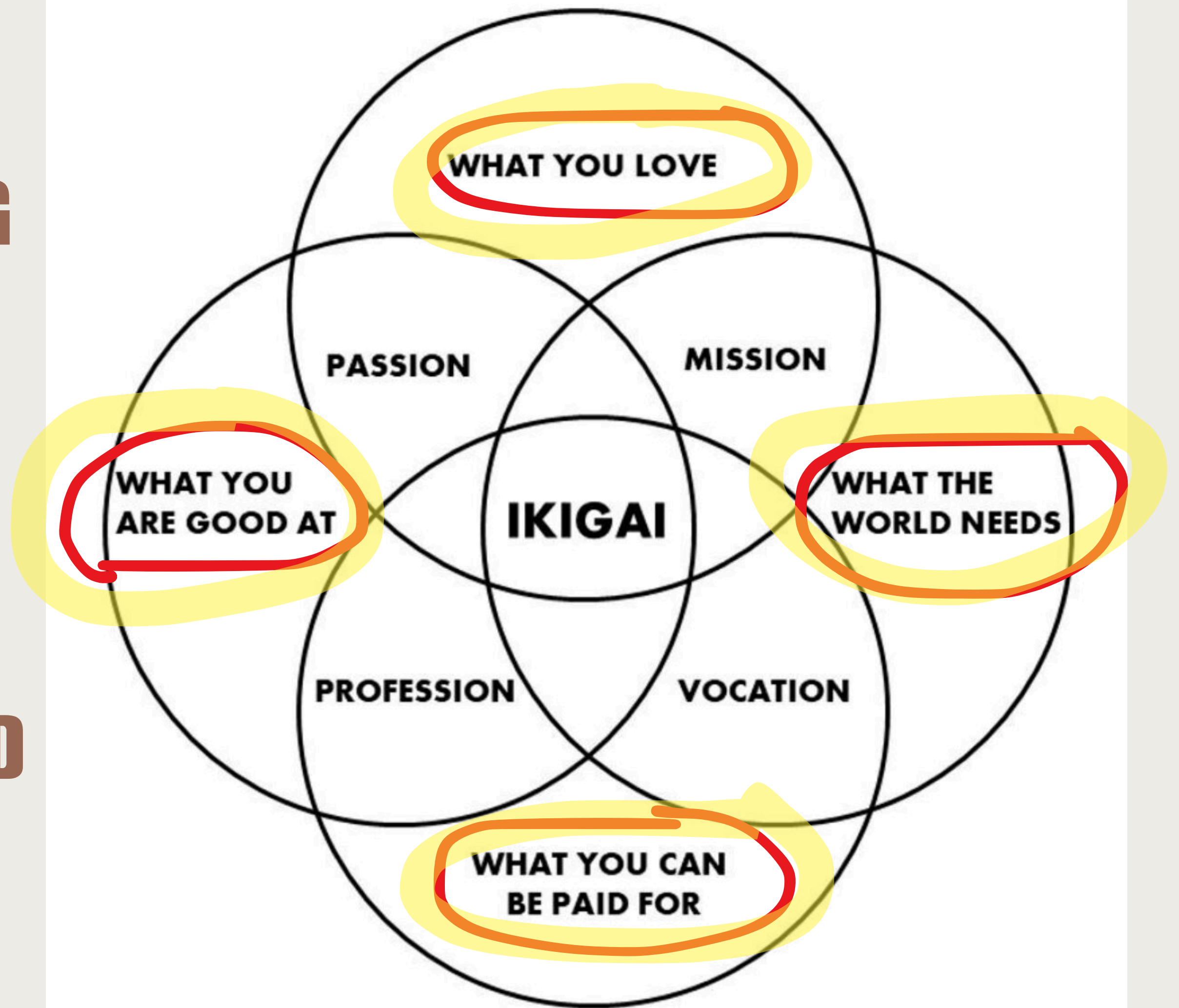
Ikigai is a Japanese concept • ~ roughly translated as "reason for being." It sits at the intersection of four questions:

1. **What you love** — topics, activities, or problems energize you? What would you do on a weekend morning with no obligations?
2. **What you're good at** — skills, talents, things people come to you for. Not just hard skills — maybe you're the person who explains complex things simply, or who calms a room down.
3. **What the world needs** — where is there a gap, a problem, an underserved audience? What frustrates you about your industry, your city, your community?
4. **What you can be paid for** — what does the market actually reward? Where does your skill meet demand?

**15 MINUTES
ON PAPER
SOLO DEEP THINKING**

**BULLET SEVERAL
IDEAS IN ALL 4
QUESTIONS**

**BE HONEST AND KIND
WITH YOURSELF...**



BEST INTERVIEW QUESTIONS

**WITH A PARTNER, ASK THEM 2-3 OF
THE BEST QUESTIONS FROM HERE...**



Posted on LinkedIn

Some of my favorite interview questions that you recommended: | Joel Hellermark

Some of my favorite interview questions that you recommended: - Pick an area you know really well. Take 5 minutes to prepare and then teach me everything I should know about it. Max Niederhofer dennis müller - What's the hardest you've ever...

 LinkedIn

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**NEWS FROM NADIA AND
REAL SUPPORT NEEDED...**

stealth, MVP and soft launch timeline is tricky...

please do an identity audit for CMO / co-founder role, ahead of fundraising; how can i be ready for investors (a friends & family round alongside angels and VCs who are strangers)?

- **#1 LinkedIn: Nadia Garfunkel**
- **#2 website: nadiagarfunkel.com**
- (eventually we will have a company website that I will promote directly)
- (obviously our pitch deck will be the key selling point)

feel free to audit the team too...

- Abdelaziz Ben Abid
- Maxandre Michel

FINAL PROJECT ASSIGNMENT

featuring guest judge :)

PERSONAL BRAND PITCH FT. VISUALS

Every student will individually present yourselves, with a strong personal brand, **targeted to a desired industry, company, or specific audience (can fabricate).**

1. **one newly designed artifact** (ex: stylized web portfolio, new Instagram account with content, etc. – whatever format and platform serves *your* purpose)
2. accompanied by a **3-minute English pitch** explaining unique positioning, skills, ideas, services, etc. ...
please memorize or use hand-written notes! prove that you learned something from this class...

INSPIRATION

Example personal brand: *"I make educational content about finance for people who did not grow up wealthy. Targeting fintech brands looking for creators."* → artifact = new TikTok account with a few videos up

Example personal brand: *"I bridge data and storytelling as a consultant, helping numbers make sense to non-technical teams. Targeting small & medium-sized businesses."* → artifact = new LinkedIn company page (entrepreneur work)

GUEST JUDGE TO HELP EVALUATE...

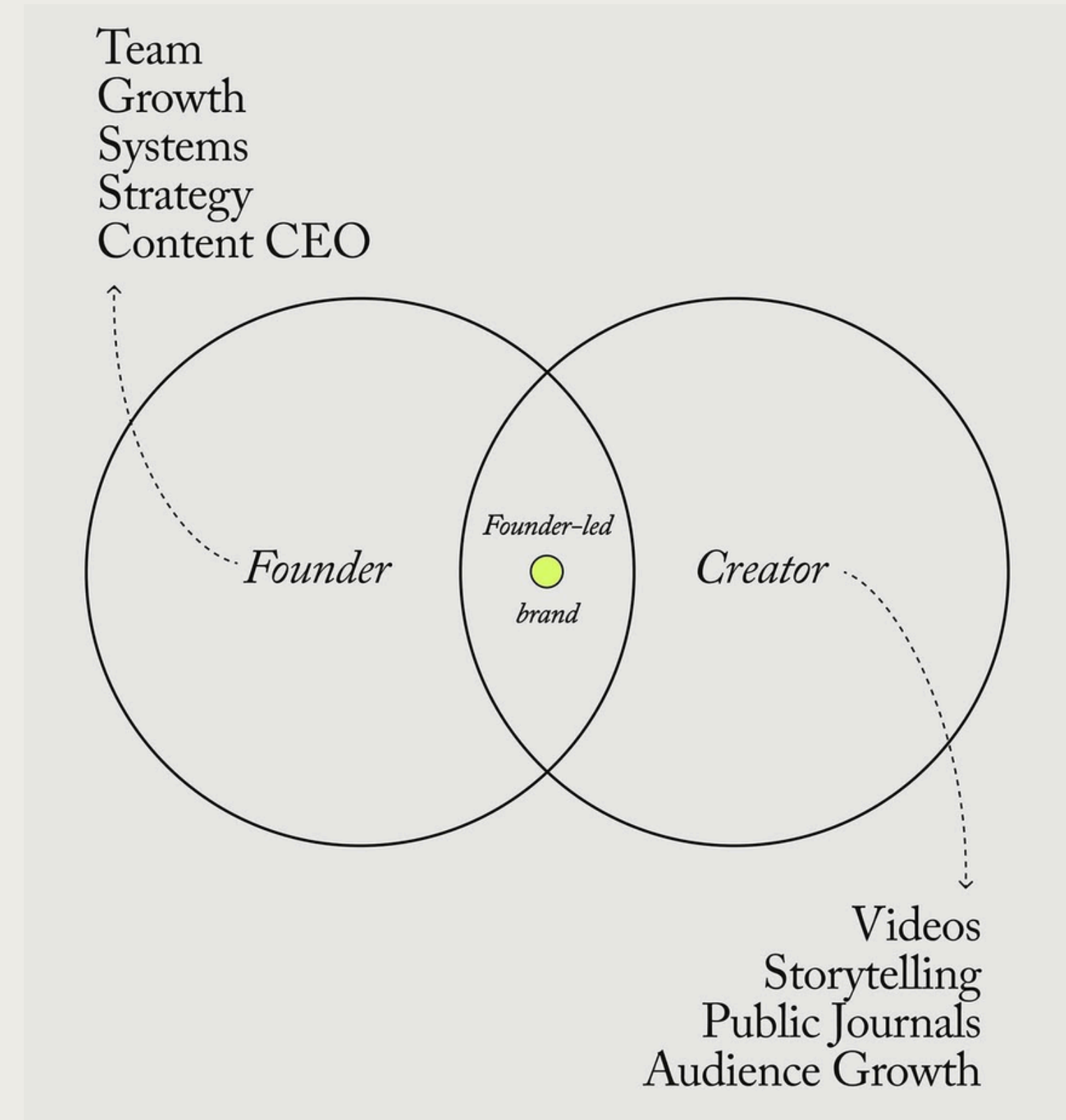
Kaja Kubica, ex-YouTuber, now does marketing at Photoroom



FINAL PROJECT WORK TIME NOW

Before you leave class today, share your:

1. targeted industry, company, or audience
2. format of what your artifact will be (and why)





**“MY FIT IS UNBO AND I
ONLY DO COOL SHIT IN
DOPE VENUES”
- JONAS COHEN**

**DOES THIS MATCH HIS
PERSONAL BRAND????**